Request for Proposal (RFP)

Northstar Outfitters — E-Commerce Platform Modernization

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1. Company Background

Northstar Outfitters is a mid-sized retailer specializing in outdoor and recreational equipment.

The company has operated for approximately eight years and currently sells its products through physical retail stores and an online store.

During the last two years, online sales have grown significantly. The company expects this growth to continue and considers its online channel an increasingly important part of its business.

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2. Current Situation

Northstar Outfitters currently operates an online commerce platform that was developed several years ago by an external development team.

The platform is operational and supports the company's current online sales activities. However, the company has identified several limitations that are becoming increasingly important as the business grows.

The main concerns are:

- Performance problems during periods of high activity.
- Reliability issues.
- Difficulty introducing new functionality.
- A growing number of manual operational processes.
- Difficulties integrating the online operation with other business systems.
- Limited and potentially outdated technical documentation.

The existing platform consists of a mixture of older and newer components. Some functionality has been added during the last two years, but documentation for these changes is incomplete.

The original external development team is no longer contracted by Northstar Outfitters.

Two internal IT employees have extensive knowledge of the business processes and have worked with the existing platform for several years.

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3. Project Objective

Northstar Outfitters is seeking a software development partner to evaluate and modernize its e-commerce capabilities.

The selected partner will be expected to understand the current business and technical situation and propose an appropriate solution.

The company does not require that the existing platform be completely replaced.

The preferred approach is to reuse existing components where technically and economically reasonable.

However, Northstar Outfitters is willing to consider a complete or partial replacement if the assessment demonstrates that modernization of the existing platform would introduce excessive technical risk, cost, or complexity.

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4. Business Objectives

The proposed solution should help Northstar Outfitters:

1. Improve the reliability of the online store.
2. Support continued growth in online sales.
3. Reduce the time and complexity associated with introducing new functionality.
4. Reduce manual processes currently performed by employees.
5. Improve integration between the online store and existing business systems.

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5. Initial Scope

The initial project is expected to focus on the company's online commerce operation.

The solution should consider, at minimum:

- Product availability and catalog information.
- Customer interactions with the online store.
- Shopping and order processes.
- Integration with existing business systems.
- Operational processes associated with online orders.

The exact scope will be refined during the discovery and requirements analysis phases.

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6. Project Timeline

Northstar Outfitters would like to have an initial version of the proposed solution available within approximately **six months** from project initiation.

The company expects the development partner to propose an appropriate implementation strategy and identify risks that could affect this timeline.

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7. Existing Systems and Information

Northstar Outfitters can provide the development partner with:

- Existing source code.
- Access to the development environment.
- Database documentation.
- Access to the development database, subject to appropriate authorization.
- Available technical documentation.
- A list of known technologies and third-party systems.
- Access to internal IT personnel.
- Access to relevant operational personnel.

Northstar Outfitters acknowledges that some of this information may be incomplete or outdated.

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8. Expected Vendor Activities

The selected development partner is expected to:

- Analyze the current business situation.
- Understand the existing platform.
- Identify relevant technical and business risks.
- Evaluate the feasibility of modifying or replacing existing components.
- Identify opportunities for process automation.
- Propose an appropriate software solution.
- Define the scope of an initial implementation.
- Provide a high-level implementation plan.
- Identify relevant risks, assumptions, and dependencies.

Detailed technical requirements have intentionally not been defined in this RFP. Northstar Outfitters expects the selected partner to help establish them during the discovery process.

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9. Success Criteria

The project will be considered successful if the resulting solution:

- Provides a more reliable online commerce experience.
- Can support the expected growth of the business.
- Allows new functionality to be introduced more efficiently.
- Reduces selected manual operational activities.
- Provides appropriate integration with existing business systems.
- Can be maintained and evolved by the company's development or technology teams.

Specific measurable targets will be established during requirements analysis.

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10. Constraints and Considerations

The following considerations should be taken into account:

- The existing platform is currently operational and supports an active business.
- A complete replacement is considered higher risk than incremental modernization.
- The existing technical documentation may be incomplete.
- The original external development team is no longer available.
- Internal IT personnel are available to provide business and technical knowledge.
- The initial implementation is expected within approximately six months.
- The solution should take into account both current requirements and anticipated business growth.

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11. Requested Proposal

Northstar Outfitters expects the selected partner to eventually provide:

- Proposed solution.
- Functional and non-functional requirements.
- High-level architecture.
- Implementation approach.
- Project roadmap.
- Risk assessment.
- Estimated effort.
- Testing and quality approach.
- Deployment approach.
- Maintenance and support considerations.

The level of detail will be refined as the discovery process progresses.

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12. Important Note

This document represents the company's **initial understanding of the project**.

It should not be considered a complete requirements specification.

Northstar Outfitters expects the development partner to challenge assumptions, identify missing information, ask questions, and propose improvements where appropriate.